Reference Event 1: The Fire at the Diehl Plant in Berlin, 3 May 2024

Characterization Against the Defense Industrial Base Sector Design Basis

DBA-DIB-RE-1 — Reference Event Instrument, DBA-DIB Series

Lineage: Issued under the Defense Industrial Base Sector Framework v0.4; DBA-MA Parent Framework; conferred on the proposal of Defense Production and Sustainment (DBA-DIB-DP-FC1)

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This version is a member of CIKR Design Basis Examples, Edition 1 (November 2026) (https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23863986), a dated edition that freezes, for each of fifteen critical infrastructure sectors, a sector framework, a facility class and a reference event as they stood on 1 November 2026. The edition is not falsified by a later revision of this document, whose working master continues to move. It is a working draft, marked DRAFT on its cover.

1. Purpose, Scope and Position

1.1 Purpose

This instrument reads the fire at the Diehl group's plant in Berlin-Lichterfelde of 3 May 2024 back through DBA-DIB-DP-FC1 (*Defense Production and Sustainment*), whose category of loss of a facility by fire (§5.1) it characterizes, at a site of the kind the class's first reference facility, the ammunition and energetics plant, is meant to protect (§1.3). The class proposed the event for its category of sabotage of a production facility (§5.2); on the author's ruling of 14 October 2026 to follow the criminal record, it is read under §5.1, and §5.2 is read only for the investigation the fire received. It asks whether the class's design basis anticipated what happened, and returns what it finds.

1.2 Position and Scope

A reference event instrument, in the series convention, reads a real event backward through the design basis, adds no requirements of its own, and returns findings and recommendations for disposition. This one is issued under the Defense Industrial Base Sector Framework v0.4, inherits the DBA-MA parent framework, and was conferred by the framework's §9.1 on the author's decision of 14 October 2026, on the proposal of *Defense Production and Sustainment*. It is the series' first reference event instrument. Section references of the bare form §N are to that class at v0.1, the version this instrument read.

The scope runs from the fire of 3 May 2024, through the police investigation, the insurers' finding of June 2024 and the reporting of suspected sabotage, to the Berlin public prosecutor's closing of the proceedings in December 2024 and the reporting since. The criminal record is closed. The suspicion of a foreign hand, reported from unnamed security sources, has not been proven or withdrawn, and in that respect the record is open.

No individual is named. The Diehl group, its subsidiary Diehl Metal Applications and its defense unit Diehl Defence, the Berlin police and public prosecutor and the newspapers are named as institutions. No government has attributed the fire to a state; the suspicion reported is that of unnamed officials as the newspapers report it. Each account is stated as its author's, and this instrument makes no finding of attribution and none of fault.

The plant lies within this class only by its owner: as Section 3.1 states, the company says the site makes metal products and does not supply its defense unit. The Foundational Definitions are cited by designation, FD-REG holding their versions; none is under load in this instrument.

2. Sources and Attribution

2.1 Sources and Their Limit

The sources are: Tagesspiegel's report of 3 to 7 May 2024, for the site, the company's account of it and the police's first statements; Der Spiegel's report as carried by the Kyiv Independent on 25 June 2024, for the authorities' and insurers' findings to that date; the Wall Street Journal's report of 24 June 2024 as carried by the Kyiv Independent; The Telegraph's report, published before April 2025, citing European security sources; and T-Online's report of 12 December 2024 on the Berlin public prosecutor's closing of the proceedings. The prosecutor's own statement was read only as reported. No non-public material is used.

2.2 Where the Sources Differ

The Berlin public prosecutor closed the proceedings in December 2024, finding no indication of intentional or negligent arson and pointing to an electrotechnical cause; the company's insurers had attributed the fire to technical problems in June 2024. Against these, the Wall Street Journal reported in June 2024 that unnamed security officials believed Russian saboteurs were likely behind the fire, and that intercepts said to show Russian involvement were not admissible in German courts; and The Telegraph reported that suspected Russian agents had researched the site's fire safety before the fire, while the investigation had not found hard proof. The company has said it assumes a technical defect and that sabotage could not in theory be excluded. Each is stated as its author's.

3. The Event

3.1 The Site

The site in Lichterfelde belongs to the Diehl group and is operated by its subsidiary Diehl Metal Applications, which coats and stamps metal parts. The company said the site does not belong to Diehl Defence and does not supply it, and that Diehl Defence had had an office at the site until February 2024. Diehl Defence makes the IRIS-T SLM air-defense system supplied to Ukraine (Tagesspiegel).

3.2 The Fire

On 3 May 2024 a fire broke out in the plant's production building, which partly collapsed; it was demolished under police cordon on 7 May. The police said there were no signs of outside involvement, considered negligent causes possible, and passed the investigation to the state criminal police's arson unit (Tagesspiegel).

3.3 The Findings and the Suspicion

On 21 June 2024 the company's insurers attributed the fire to technical problems, and the company said it assumed a technical defect that was not its fault (Der Spiegel). On 24 June the Wall Street Journal reported the suspicion of unnamed security officials described in Section 2.2. The Telegraph later reported that the authorities had first ruled the fire an accident and reopened the inquiry on intelligence from a foreign ally. On 12 December 2024 the Berlin public prosecutor closed the proceedings, a spokesperson stating that there were no indications of intentional or negligent arson and that months of investigation pointed to an electrotechnical cause (T-Online). No charge has been brought.

4. Technical Decomposition

The event decomposes into initiating elements (I-1 to I-3) and effect elements (E-1 to E-4), as Table 4-1 sets out. Composed, they are the class's loss of a facility by fire (§5.1), at a site of a defense group that is not itself a defense production facility, investigated as the possible sabotage of §5.2 and closed as an accident, with the suspicion unproven.

Table 4-1. Event elements and their mapping. Section references are to *Defense Production and Sustainment* v0.1.

No.	What happened	Class provision	Section
I-1	A site of a defense group, making metal parts, not supplying the defense unit	Applicability (§6.1); owner as target (§5.2)	3.1
I-2	Fire in a production building	Loss of a facility by fire (§5.1)	3.2
I-3	Investigation by the arson unit, reopened on foreign intelligence	Investigated as possibly deliberate (§5.2)	3.2, 3.3
E-1	Building partly collapsed and demolished	Production recovery time (§3.3)	3.2
E-2	Insurers and prosecutor: technical, electrotechnical cause	Investigation until it can state (§5.2)	3.3
E-3	Officials' suspicion of Russian saboteurs; intercepts inadmissible	Uncertainty of an unattributed event (§5.2)	2.2
E-4	No charge; suspicion unproven	Pattern across facilities (§5.2)	3.3

5. Tier Determination

5.1 The Four Characteristics

No adversary is established on the record. The criminal investigation closed finding no arson; the suspicion of a foreign hand is unnamed officials' as reported. Intentionality, persistence, precision and denial are therefore not determined.

5.2 Determination

The event does not meet the threshold for the military-action extension. On the record it is a fire at a defense group's metal-products site, closed by the prosecutor as an electrotechnical accident, realizing the class's §5.1, with the sabotage of §5.2 suspected by unnamed officials and unproven. If a later investigation establishes a deliberate act and attributes it, the instrument is revised. That is the tier determination returned for the DBA Reference Event Register. No impacted sector beyond the Defense Industrial Base is proposed.

6. Characterization Against the Design Basis

6.1 §5.2 and §1.3 The Class's Account of the Event

Held, with a gap. The account holds in the accounts it gives: the company's technical-fault view, the Wall Street Journal's and The Telegraph's reports, and the absence of a charge. Three points are qualified and go to the class as Erratum 1 of Project 11's note of 14 October 2026 (Defense Industrial Base batch). The Berlin public prosecutor closed the proceedings in December 2024, finding no indication of intentional or negligent arson and an electrotechnical cause, which the class does not record. The site is operated by Diehl Metal Applications, which coats and stamps metal parts and, on the company's account, does not supply Diehl Defence, which had left the site in February 2024; the class's description of the site as an energetics or ammunition plant, implied by §1.3, does not hold. And the Wall Street Journal's details that the fire began in an area few could enter and that video records were destroyed could not be confirmed in the sources read and should be attributed to the Journal as the class read it.

6.2 §5.2 Investigated From the Start as Possibly Deliberate

Held, with a gap. The class requires that an event at a first-tier facility be investigated from the start as possibly deliberate, with the agencies that would investigate an attack. The state's arson unit took the case at once, and the inquiry was reopened on a foreign ally's intelligence. The event adds that the investigation could not state whether the fire was deliberate in the way the class needs: the evidence said to show a foreign hand was intelligence not admissible in court, and the criminal finding and the security assessment parted. Finding F-1.

6.3 §6.1 and §5.2 The Site Chosen for Its Owner

Held, with a gap. The class's reading, that a plant can be attacked because of what its owner is known for whatever its own products, is the suspicion the officials reported. But the class's applicability determination (§6.1) is made by each first- and second-tier facility, and this site, making coated and stamped parts for other industries, would not have made one. Finding F-2.

6.4 §5.1 Loss of a Facility by Fire

Held. A production building burned and was demolished; the class's provisions for restoration and for the protective functions against a facility's own hazard read it. The company reported the plant back in operation, as the Kyiv Independent reported in June 2024.

6.5 §6.3 The Governing Military-Action Scenario

Not exercised. No strike and no established sabotage.

6.6 §7.3 The AI-Governance Design Basis

Not exercised. No component within the scope of *Layer Decomposition and Determinism* §4.3 bore on the event.

6.7 Summary of Design Basis Performance

Of the six readings, three Held, with a gap, the class's account among them; one Held; and two were Not exercised. Nothing was Missed. The event was proposed for §5.2 and, on the author's ruling to follow the closed criminal record, is read under §5.1; it tests §5.2's investigation requirement and finds it able to start but not to finish. What the event adds is that the design-basis response to a suspected sabotage cannot wait on a criminal finding the intelligence may never support, and that a defense group's other sites carry its reputation as a target.

7. Findings

Section references are to *Defense Production and Sustainment* v0.1 unless another instrument is named.

7.1 F-1 — The Protective Response Rests on the Security Assessment, Not Only the Criminal Finding

The state's arson unit investigated the fire and the inquiry was reopened on foreign intelligence; unnamed officials believed Russian saboteurs likely responsible and said the intercepts were not admissible in court; the prosecutor closed the proceedings finding no arson (Sections 2.2 and 3.3). The finding confirms §5.2's requirement that an event be investigated as possibly deliberate and reported so that a pattern can be seen, and is that the class should state two tracks: the criminal investigation, which may end without a finding, and a security assessment by the agencies that hold the intelligence, which states to the facility and to the coordination class whether the event is to be treated as a possible attack; and that the protective posture of other first-tier facilities is set on the assessment, under a named authority, without waiting on the criminal finding.

Affected: §5.2, §6.1. Disposition: R-1; noted to the coordination class.

7.2 F-2 — A Defense Group's Other Sites Carry Its Reputation

The site coated and stamped metal parts for several industries and, on the company's account, did not supply the group's defense unit, which had left it three months before; it was reported as a target because of the group's defense role (Sections 3.1 and 3.3). The finding confirms §5.2's reading that a plant can be attacked for what its owner is known for, and is that the class should state that the applicability determination of §6.1 is made by the company for every site that carries its name, not only for its first- and second-tier facilities, so that a site with no defense production of its own but a known defense owner states its exposure to sabotage, and the protective measures of §5.2 reach it in proportion.

Affected: §5.2, §6.1. Disposition: R-2.

8. Recommendation Register

Priority is on the series' one-to-three scale, 1 the most consequential. R-1 and R-2 dispose to *Defense Production and Sustainment*.

No.	Title	Affected	Recommendation	Pri.
R-1	Set the protective response on the security assessment	§5.2, §6.1	State a security-assessment track beside the criminal one, informing the facility and coordination class whether to treat the event as a possible attack; set other facilities' posture on it. Noted to the coordination class.	1
R-2	Extend applicability to a defense group's other sites	§5.2, §6.1	Make the applicability determination for every site carrying the company's name, so a site with a known defense owner states its sabotage exposure.	2

9. Open Items

OI-1: the register row. Project 0 is asked to enter the tier determination of Section 5.2. OI-2: the class has not taken in this instrument and conforms at its next revision, with Erratum 1. OI-3: closed. The author ruled on 14 October 2026 to follow the criminal record; the event is read under §5.1, and whether another event is sought for §5.2 is Project 9's.

10. Standing of This Document

10.1 What This Instrument Establishes

It modifies neither class nor framework, and makes no finding of attribution and none of fault.

10.2 Relationship to the Class's Use Case

The class's use case traces §6.3, production struck at depth, combined with sabotage of plants beyond reach. This event supplies the figures for how a suspected sabotage is handled when nothing is proven: an arson unit at once, a reopening on a foreign ally's intelligence, a closing seven months after the fire with no arson found, and a suspicion that persisted in the press. F-1 bears on how the use case's coordination class would respond to a string of such fires during a campaign. The sabotage itself is the use case's construction.

10.3 Relationship to Other Instruments

Ukrainian Strikes on Russian Defense Production (DBA-DIB-RE-2) reads production struck by a belligerent in war.

References

Tagesspiegel, *„Keine Fremdeinwirkung": Großbrand in Berliner Metalltechnik-Firma wohl durch Unfall verursacht*, 3 May 2024, updated 7 May 2024. Kyiv Independent, *Russian saboteurs likely behind arson attack on German factory, security officials tell WSJ*, 24 June 2024; *Media: German authorities find no evidence of Russian attack on metal factory*, 25 June 2024. The Telegraph, *Russian agents researched fire safety at German arms firm before arson attack*, as syndicated, before April 2025. T-Online, *Ende der Spekulationen: Verfahren nach Großbrand in Berlin-Lichterfelde eingestellt*, 12 December 2024. The DBA instruments named in the text, with the Foundational Definitions and FD-REG, and the DBA-MA Parent Framework.

Revision History

Version 0.1, 14 October 2026: issued in Project 11 under the Defense Industrial Base Sector Framework v0.4, on the conferral of the framework's §9.1 of 14 October 2026, read against *Defense Production and Sustainment* v0.1. Written new under the Reference Event Compression Standard v0.3, the series' first reference event instrument. Tier determination at Section 5.2; F-1 and F-2, R-1 and R-2. The class's account is qualified on three points going to the class as Erratum 1 of Project 11's note of 14 October 2026 (Defense Industrial Base batch).

Version 0.2, 14 October 2026: on the author's ruling of 14 October 2026 to follow the criminal record, reads the event under the class's §5.1, loss of a facility by fire, rather than §5.2, sabotage, for which the class proposed it; §5.2 is read only for the investigation the fire received. Section 1.1 and Section 6.7 are conformed and OI-3 is closed. The characteristics, the tier, the findings and the recommendations are unchanged. Version 0.1 is in the series' _archive.